- increase school enrolment and attendance of children
- reorient good eating habits.
- incorporate nutrition education into curriculum.
- improve literacy and educational performance of pupils.
- encourage the use of local commodities.
- encourage community participation in the feeding programme.

The Mid-Day Meal Programme for school children comes under the Ministry of Human Development. The Government of India pays 40 percent of the expenditure and 60 percent is borne by the States. It covers all children upto the age of 15 years.

The Mid-Day Meal Programme was introduced in a large scale in 1960's by K.Kamarajar, former chief minister of Tamilnadu. But the first major thrust came in 1st july 1982 when the then chief minister of Tamilnadu DR.M.G.Ramachandran decided to implement the scheme for all children in goverment schools in primary classes. In this programme, students from classes I to V in Corporation, Government and Government aided schools are given free mid-day meal for 200 days in a year. Under this programme, the Government of India provides 100 grams of rice, 15 grams of dhal, 1 grams of oil and 20 paise worth of vegetables per indiviual. The meal given are based on a combination of cereals, pulses and leafy vegetables. Eggs are given thrice a week. Such a diet would increase the amount of vitamins and minerals and results in weight gain and clearance of deficiency symptoms.

What do children eat today in their midday meal :

- Upto 5th standard, 100 grams of rice per child per day
- Upto 10th standard, 150 grams of rice per child per day
- Egg on all working days. Banana alternative for vegetarians.
- First and third week of month, pulav made of black Bengal gram given for protein
- Second and fourth week, green gram sundal
- Fridays, chilli fried potato for carbohydrates
- Use of double fortified salt
- Sweet pongal is served on occasions

ACTIVITY

4. Visit the nearest noon meal centre in your area and find out the following details:
5. How many eggs are given per week for the beneficiaries? What are the benefits of giving eggs to the children?
6. Write the weekly menu given in the noon meal centre in your school.

Mid-Day meal programme has resulted in the following:

- Reduction in severe malnutrition in children.
- Increased enrolment rate at primary level.

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